

SCOTS PROVERBS,

ANCIENT AND MODERN,

SELECTED FROM

ALLAN RAMSAY AND OTHERS.

“An ounce o’ mither-wit, is worth a pound o’ clergy.”

BRECHIN:

PRINTED FOR ALEXANDER BLACK, BOOKSELLER.

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PROVERBS, ANCIENT AND MODERN, SELECTED FROM ALLAN
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SCOTS PROVERBS.

A

A bairn may hae ower muckle o' his mither's benison.

A bare moor maks a lean hirsle.

A' burdens are light except to the bearer.

A blate maiden may mak a bardy gudewife.

A blate suitor should hae a gude cause.

A' blews are no true blews.

A borrowing man is a sorrowing man.

A begun turn is hauf ended.

A blate cat maks a proud mouse.

A blythe heart maks a blooming look.

A bit but, and a bit ben, maks a mim-mou'd maiden at the board en'.

A bonny bride is soon busket, and a short horse is soon whisket.

A borrowed len' shou'd gae laughing hame.

Abundance of law breaks nae law.

A careless maister maks a lazy man.

A club fit will no mak a gude shinty.

A close mouth catches nae flees.

A cock's ay crouse on his ain midden-head.

A cramm'd kyte maks a crazy carcass.

A daft nurse maks a wise wean.

A denk maiden maks a dirty wife.

A drink is shorter than a tale.

A dry summer ne'er made a dear peck.

A dumb man wins nae law.

Ae bird in the hand is worth ten fleein' by.

A fool may win money, but it taks a wise man to keep it.

A greedy e'e ne'er had a leel heart.

Ae gade turn deserves anither.

Ae hour's cauld will suck out seven yeer's heat.

Ae man may lead a horse to the water, but twenty winna gar him drink.

Ae man's meat is anither man's poison.

Ae swallow maks na simmer.

Ae scabbed sheep will smit the hale hirtel.

Ae hour in the morning is worth twa in the afternoon.

A fidging mare shou'd be weel girded.

A fleer wad aye hae a follower.

A fool and his money is soon parted.

A fool may gi'e a wise man a counsel.

A friend in court is worth a penny in purse.

A friend in need's a friend indeed.

Aft counting keeps friends lang thegither.

After meat mustard.

After a storm comes a ca'm.

A fou man and a hungry horse ay mak haste hame.

A fou purse never lacks friends.

A rough bane maks a fou wame.

A fou wame maks a stiff back.

A black hen lays a white egg.

A gaun foot's ay getting.

A gentle horse shou'd be sindle spurr'd.
A gi'en horse shou'd na be look'd i' the mouth.
A gi'en game was ne'er won.
A gude beginning maks a gude ending.
A gude cow may hae an ill cauf.
A gude tongue's a safe weapon.
A gude ingle maks a roomy fire-side.
A gude word is as soon said as an ill.
A gude tale is no the waur to be twice tauld.
A gude name is sooner tint than won.
A green turf's a gude gudemither.
A green Yule maks a fat kirk-yard.
A great cry and little woo, quoth the deil, when he clippet the sow.
A greedy e'e never gat a gude penny worth.
A hantle cry murder, and are ay uppermost.
A houndless hunter, and a gunless gunner, see ay routh o' game.
A hungry man's ay angry.
Ale sellers shou'd na be tale-tellers.
A liar shou'd hae a gude memory.
Alike ilka day maks a clout on Sunday.
A light purse maks a heavy heart.
A's no gowd that glitters.
A' the truth shou'd na be tauld.
A' the corn's no shorn by kempers.
A' the winning's in the first buying.
A' that's said in the kitchen shou'd na be tauld in the ha'.

A' cats are grey i' the dark.
A's no tint that's in hazard.
A's fish that comes i' the net.
A' Stewarts are no sib to the king.
A' the speed's i' the spurs.
A's weel that ends weel.
A' things are gude untried.
A red nose maks a raggit back.
A kiss and a drink o' water maks a wersh breakfast.
A man's ay crouse on his ain cause.
A man may spit in his loof and do little.
A man canna bear a' his kin on his back.
A man at five may be a fool at fifteen.
A man is weel or wae, as he thinks himsel sae.
A mouthfu' o' meat may be a townfu' o' shame.
A muffled cat was ne'er a gude hunter.
An auld mason maks a gude barrowman.
An ill shearer never gat a gude heuk.
An ill-willy cow shou'd hae short horns.
An ill servant ne'er prov'd a gude master.
An ounce of mither-wit is worth a pound o' clergy.
Ane may lo'e the kirk weel aneugh, yet no be ay riding on the rigging
o't.
A Scots mist will weet an Englishman to the skin.
As fu' o' mischief as an egg's fu' o' meat.
As gude may haud the stirrip as he that louns on.

As lang runs the fox as he has feet.
As lang lives the merry man as the sad.
As lang as ye serve the tod ye maun bear up his tail.
As the sow fills the draff sours.
As the auld cock craws, the young cock learns.
As the fool thinks, the bell clinks.
As the market gangs the wares maun sell.
As weel be hang'd for a wedder as a lamb.
As ye lo'e me look in my dish.
As ye do yoursel you judge your neibours.
As ye mak your bed, sae ye maun lie down.
A safe conscience maks a sound sleep.
A sillerless man gangs fast through the market.
A sinking master maks aft a rising man.
A slothfu' hand maks a slim fortune.
As ye brew weel ye'll drink the better.
A spur in the head is worth twa in the heel.
A sturdy beggar shou'd hae a stout naysayer.
A tale-teller is waur than a thief.
A taking hand will never want.
A tale never tines in the telling.
A wight man never wanted a weapon.
A thread will tye an honest man better than a rape a knave.
A tocherless dame sits lang at hame.
A twapenny cat may look at a king.
A wee bush is better than nae bield.

A wee thing fleys cowards.

Auld men are twice bairns.

Auld sparrows are ill to tame.

Auld springs gi'e nae price.

A yeld sow was never gude to grices.

B

Bare gentry, bragging beggars.—Bastard brood are ay proud.
Be lang sick that ye may be soon hale.
Beggars shou'd na be choosers.
Beg frae beggars you'll never be rich.
Better a bit i' the morning than fast a' day.
Better a clout than a hole out.
Better a dog fawn on you than bark at you.
Better a finger aff than ay wagging.
Better a mouse in the pat than nae flesh.
Better a tocher in her than wi' her.
Better a toom house than an ill tenant.
Better a wee ingle to warm you, than a muckle fire to burn you.
Better auld debts than auld sairs.
Better sma' fish than nae fish.
Better be alane than in ill company.
Better be blythe wi' little than sad wi' naethin'.
Better be envied than pitied.—Better be idle than ill employed.
Better be out o' the warld than out o' the fashion.
Better be kind than cumbersome.
Better buy than berrow.—Better day the better deed.
Better eat grey bread in youth than in eild.
Better flatter a fool than fight wi' him.
Better find iron than tine siller.—Better gi'e the slight than tak it.

Better haud by a hair than draw wi' a tether.
Better ha'f egg than toom doup.
Better hain at the brim than at the bottom.
Better hand loose than in an ill tethering.
Better kiss a knave than cast out wi' him.
Better keep the deil without the door than drive him out o' the house.
Better keep weel than mak weel.
Better late thrive than ne'er do weel.
Better live in hope than in despair.
Better my bairns seek frae me than I beg frae them.
Better my friend think me fremit than fashious.
Better ne'er begun than ne'er ended.
Better rue sit than rue flit.—Blude's thicker than water.
Better the end of a feast than the beginning of a fray.
Better to haud than to draw.—Better twa skaiths than ae sorrow.
Better wait on the cook than the doctor.
Better wear shoon than sheets.—Black will tak nae ither hue.
Between the deil and the deep sea.—Burnt bairns the fire dreads.
Bid a man to the roast and stick him wi' the spit.
Bigging and bairns marrying are great wasters.
Birds of a feather flock thegither.
Birth's gude but breeding's better.
Biting and scarting is Scotch fouk's wooing.
Blind men shou'd na be judges o' colours.
Boden gear stinks.—Bourd na wi' Bawty lest he bite ye.
Broken bread makes hale bairns.

Butter and burn trouts are kittle meat for maidens.

Buy a thief frae the gallows and he'll cut your throat.

C

Cadgers are ay fond o' creels.
Cast a cat o'er the house rigging 'twill fa' on its feet.
Cast a bane in the deil's teeth.
Cats an carlins sit in the sun.
Cauld cools the love that kindles ower het.
Changes are lightsome.
Charity begins at hame.
Come unca'd sits unserv'd.
Comes to my hand like the boul of a pint stoup.
Come wi' the wind and gae wi' the water.
Confess'd faut is hauf amends.
Confess debt and crave days.
Confess and be hang'd.
Corn him weel, he'll work the better.
Count again is not forbidden.
Count siller after a' your kin.
Count like Jews and 'gree like brethren.
Credit is better than ill won gear.
Credit keeps the crown o' our causeway.
Crooked carlin, quoth the cripple to his wife.
Cut your coat according to your claith.
Corbys will no pick out corby's een.

D

Daffin and want o' wit maks auld wives denard.

Damming and laving is gude sure fishing.

Daughters and dead fish are nae keeping ware.

Dawted bairns dow bear little.

Day-light will peep through a sma' hole.

Dear bought and far sought is meat for ladies.

Death and marriage break term-day.

Death defies the doctor.

Ding down the nest and the rooks will flee away.

Dinna gut your fish till ye get them.

Dit your mouth wi' your meat.

Do as the lasses do, say no and tak it.

Dinna meddle wi' the deil and the laird's bairns.

Dogs will redd swine.

Dows and dominies leave ay a foul house.

Double charges rive cannons.

Drink he sought, but draff was his errand.

Draff's gude enough for swine.

Drive a cow to the ha' she'll rin to the byre.

Drink and drouth come na ay thegether.

Drink little that ye may drink lang.

Drunken at e'en and dry in the morning.

Dummie winna lie.

E

Early master soon knave.—Eat your fill but pouch nane.

Eat pease wi' the prince, and cherries wi' the chapman.

Eat in measure and defy the doctor.

Eat weel's drink weel's brither.

Eating and drinking wants but a beginning.

Eild and poortith's sair to thole.

Eith learning the cat to the kirn.

Eith working when will's at hame.

Either win the horse or tine the saddle.

Either the tod or the fearn bush.

E'ening red and morning grey, is a taiken of a bonny day.

E'ening oats are gude morning fodder.

E'en as ye win't say ye may wear't.

Embroid' justice, the greater the crime the sma'er the fine.

Eneugh's as gude's a feast.

Every ane creeshes the fat sows tail.

Every ane louns the dike where it's laighest.

Every crow thinks hir ain bird whitest.

Every dog has his day.

Every man can guide an ill wife weel but he that has her.

Every man bows to the bush he gets bield frae.

Every man's tale's gude till anither's be tauld.

Every man at forty is a fool or a physician.

Every man has his ain draff pock.

Every miller wad wyse the water to his ain mill.

Every thing has an end, and a pudding has twa.

Experience teaches fools.

F

Faint heart never won fair lady.

Fair exchange is nae robbery.—Fancy kills and cures.

Fann'd fires and forc'd love ne'er did weel.

Far away fowls hae fair feathers.—Far frae court far frae care.

Far behind that may not follow.—Fast bind, fast find.

Fat paunches bode lean pows.—First come first ser'd.

Feckless foek are ay fond of ane anither.

Fiddler's wives and gamester's ale are free to every body.

Fiddler's dogs and flesh-flies come to feasts unca'd.

Fight dog, fight bear, wha won deil care.

Fine feathers mak fine birds.—Fools' haste is nae speed.

Fire and water are gude servants, but ill masters.

Flaes and a girning wife are waukrife bed-fellows.

Fleying a bird is no the way to grip it.

Flitting of farms mak mailings dear.—Friends 'gree best sindry.

Fools shou'd nae hae chapping stieks.

Fools ravel and wise men redd.—Fumblers are ay fond o' weans.

Fools and bairns shou'd nae see a ha'f done turn.

Fools mak feasts, and wise fouk eat them; the wise mak jests, and fools repeat them.

For fashion's sake, as dogs gang to the market.

Fore-warn'd, ha'f armed.—Foul water slockens fire.

Fresh fish and poor friends grow soon ill-far'd.

Friends are like fiddle-strings, they mauna be screw'd owre tight.
Frost and fausehood hae baith a dirty waygang.

G

Gaunting bodes wanting.—Gie the deil his due.

Giff-Gaff makes gude friends.—Gie you an inch ye'll tak an ell.

Gie a dog an ill name and he'll soon be hang'd.

Gie the deil his due.—Glasses and lasses are bruckle ware.

God help great fowk, the poor can beg.

God ne'er sent the mouth but he sent meat wi't.

God send you mair wit and mair siller.

Great barkers are nae biters.—Greening wives are ay greedy.

Gie a beggar a bed and he'll pay you wi' lice.

H

Haud a hank in your ain hand.—Hae gars a deaf man hear.
Hair and hair makes the earl's head bare.—Hale-sale's gude sale.
Hame is hame if it were ne'er sae hamely.
Hang them that hae nae shift, and them that hae owre mony.
Hang a thief when he's young, and he'll no steal when he's auld.
Hanging's nae better than it's ea'd.—Hardships sinle come single.
He begs frae them that borrow'd frae him.
He brings a staff to break his ain head.
He does na ay ride when he saddles his horse.
He fells twa dogs wi' ae stane.—He had his finger in the pye.
He gangs awa to an ill tune that never comes again.
He has a bee in his bannet lug.—He's like a flea in a blanket.
He has gotten a bite o' his ain bridle.
He has nae as muckle sense as a cow can haud in her faulded nieve.
He has faut of a wife that marries mam's pet.
He has mair wit in his little finger than ye hae in a' your bouk.
He has feather'd his nest, he may flee when he likes.
He has need of a lang spoon that sups wi' the deil.
He has a slid grip that has an eel by the tail.
He kens na a B by a bull's foot.—He's no sae daft as he lets on.
He kens his ain groats amang ither fouks kail.
He'll soon be a beggar that cannot say nay.
He loo'd mutton weel that licked where the ewe lay.

He'll no sell his hen on a rainy day.
He may weel swim that has his head hadden up.
He never lies but when the holly's green.
He needs maun rin that the deil drives.
He's wise that kens whan he's weel, and can haud himsel sae.
He's scant o' news that tells his father was hanged.
He's an Aberdeen's man, he taks his word again.
He's a wise bairn that kens his ain father.
He's uneo fou in his ain house that canna pike a bane in his neibour's.
He's a proud horse that winna bear his ain provender.
He's like a singet cat, better than he's likely.
He's a worthless gudeman that's no miss'd.
He stumbles at a strae and louns o'er a won-lyne.
He speaks like a prent-book.—He that comes unca'd sits unserv'd.
He that aught the cow gangs nearest her tail.
He that buys land buys stanes, and he that buys beef buys banes.
He that buys nuts buys shells, he that buys ale buys naithing else.
He that canna mak sport shou'd mar nane.
He that deals in dirt has ay foul fingers.
He that can near Dumback may bear Dumbarton.
He that keeps the cat's dish keeps her ay crying.
He rises owre soon that's hanged e'er noon.
He that gies a' wad gies naithing.—He that has muckle gets ay mair.
He that has muckle wad ay hae mair.
He that has a gude cramp may thole some thistles.
He that has nae siller in his purse shou'd hae silk on his tongue.

He that hides is the best at seeking.
He that has a muckle nose thinks ilk ane speaks o't.
He that hews aboon his head may get a speal in his e'e.
He that's ill to himsel will be gude to naebody.
He that laughs at his ain joke spills the sport o't.
He that speers a', only gets wit o' part.
He wad skin a loose for the tallow.
He that sleeps wi' dogs maun rise wi' flaes.
He's no sae daft as he's daft like.—His egg has ay twa youks.
He that winna when he may, he shanna when he wad.
He that woos a widow should woo her day and night.
He that wad eat the kirkel maun crack the nut.
He that will to Coupar will to Coupar.
He wad gang a mile to flit a sow.—He wad rake hell for a bodle.
He wats na whilk end o' him's uppermost.
He wad gar you trow that the moon's made o' green cheese.
He wad tine his lugs if they werna tacked to him.
His bark is war than his bite.—Hooly and fairly gangs far in a day.
Hungry dogs are blythe o' bursten puddings.

I

I canna sell the cow and sup her milk.—I hae ither tow on my rock.

I can see as far into a mill-stane as he that pick'd it.

I hae a gude bow, but its in the castle.

I had rather gae by your door than o'er your grave.

I hae got an ill kame for my ain head.

I hae mair ado than a dish to wash.

I hae baith my meat and my mense.

I hae seen mair than I hae eaten, or ye wadna be there.

I ken by my cog my cow's milked.—I ne'er sat on your coat tale.

I'll gar his ain gartens tye up his ain hose.

I'll ne'er lout sae laigh and lift sae little.

I'll ne'er put the rogue aboon the gentleman.

I'll ne'er keep a dog and bark mysel.

I'll tak the best first, as the priest did o' the plumbs.

I'll ne'er brew drink to treat drunkards.

I'm o'er auld a cat to draw a strae before.

I'm no sae blind as I'm bleer-ey'd.

I'm nae sae scant o' clean pipes as to blaw wi' a burnt cutty.

I'm speaking o' hay and you o' horse corn.

I'm neither sma' drink thirsty, nor grey bread hungry.

I ne'er lo'ed meat that craw'd in my crapin.

I wad be scant o' claith to sole my hose wi' dockens.

I wadna fother you for your muck.

I wadna ca the king my cousin tho' he were my uncle's son.
I wadna be deav'd wi' your keckling for a' your eggs.
I wadna mak fish o' ane and flesh o' anither.
I wish you readier meat than a rinning hare.
If ae sheep loup o'er the dike a' the lave will follow.
If and *and* spoils mony a gude charter.
If a man gangs down the brae ilk ane gies him a jundie.
If he bind the pock she'll sit down upon't.
If he be nae a souter he's a gude shoe clouter.
If I canna keep geese I'll keep gaislins.
If I canna do't by might I'll do't by sleight.
If it be a faut it's nae ferly.—If it winna sell it winna sour.
If stakes be gude to gie they'll be gude to get.
If the deil be laird ye'll be tenant.—If ye lo'e me let it kythe.
If the deil find you idle he'll set you to wark.
If wishes were horses beggars wad ride.
If ye hae little gear guide it the better.
If ye ca' me scabbed I'll ca' you sca'd.
If ye be angry, claw your wame, and cool in the skin ye het in.
If you sell your purse to your wife, gi'e her your brecks to the bargain.
If ye had as little money as ye hae manners, ye wad be the poorest man
o' your kin.
If ye win at whoring ye'll tine at naething.
If ye serve the tod ye maun bear up his tail.
Ill bairns get ay broken brows.—Ill bairns are best heard at hame.
Ill beef ne'er made good broe.—Ill doers are ay ill dreaders.

Ill counsel will gar a man stick his ain mare.
Ill getting het water frae 'neath cauld ice.—Ill herds mak fat foxes.
Ill hearing maks wrang rehearsing.—Ill news are aft owre true.
Ill laying up maks mony thieves.—Ill payers are ay gude cravers.
Ill to tak and eith to tire.—Ill weeds wax weel.
Ill workers are ay gude to putters.—Ill-will ne'er spak weel.
Ill won gear winna enrich the third heir.—Ill won, as ill wair'd.
It cam wi' the wind let it gang wi' the water.
It maun be an auld-farrant mouse that can kittle in a cat's lug.
It's a bare moor that ye gang thro' and no get a heather cow.
It's a cauld stammock that naething heats on.
It's a gude goose that draps ay.—It's a hard task to be poor and leal.
It's a gude poor man's blade, it will bow or break.
It's a lang lane that hasna a turning.
It's an ill wind that blows naebody gude.
It's an ill cause that the lawyers think shame o'.
It's time to gie owre piping when youv'e lost the upper lip.
It's an ill pack that's no worth the custom.
It's a mean mouse that has but ae hole.—It's no a' tint that fa's by.
It's a nasty bird fyles its ain nest.—It's a sin to lie on the deil.
It's a poor house whare thers's neither a bairn nor a mouse.
It's a shame to eat the cow and worry on the tail.
It's a sorry hen that canna scrape for ae bird.
It's a sair dung bairn that mayna greet.—It's gude to be sib to siller.
It's a' tint that's done to auld fo'k and bairns.
It's but kindly that the pock sa'r of the herring.

It's better to sup wi' a cutty than want a spoon.
It's dear coft honey that's lick'd aff a thorn.
It's eith crying Yule on anither man's stool.
It's fair in ha' where beards wag a'.—It's gude sleeping in a hale skin.
It's gude maut that comes o' will.—It's gude to be side but no trailing.
It's gude gear that pleases the merchant.
It's gude to be gude in your time, ye kenna how lang it may last.
It's gude to hae twa strings to your bow.
It's hard to gar an auld mare leave aff flinging.
It's hard to sit in Rome and strive wi the Pope.
It's hard for a greedy e'e to hae a leal heart.
It's ill to be ca'd a thief and no found picking.
It's ill to bring out o' the flesh what's bred i' the bane.
It's ill getting breeks aff a Higlandman.
It's ill taking corn frae geese.—It's no tint that a friend gets.
It's ill making a silk purse o' a sows lug, or a touting horn o' a tods tail.
It's ill bringing butt what's no there ben.
It's kittle shooting at corbies and clergy.
It's kittle to waken sleeping dogs.—It's needless to bid a wren rin.
It's lang or the deil be found dead at a dike-side.
It's lang or ye need to cry, shou, to an egg.
It's lang or like-to-die fill the kirk-yard.
It's muckle gars the tailor laugh, for suitors girn ay.
It's needless to pour water on a drown'd mouse.
It's no the cowl that maks the friar.—It maun be true that a' fo'k says.
It's nae sin to tak a gude price, but in gi'ing ill measure.

It's nae play when ane laughs and anither greets.
It's no what is she? but what was she?
It's nae laughing to girn in a widdy.—It's weel war'd wasters want.
It's o'er far between the kitchen and the ha'.
It's o'er late to spare when the bottom's bare.
It's past joking when the head's aff.
It's weel that our fau'ts are no written on our face.
It's time enough to skreigh when ye're stricken.
It's time enough to mak my bed when I'm gaun to lie down.
It's lang or four bare legs gather heat in the bed.
It may come in an hour that winna come in seven year.
It will be a feather out o' your wing.
It sets a sow weel to wear a saddle.
It sets you weel to gab again wi' your bannet on.
It was ne'er for naething that the gled whistled.

J

Joke at leisure, you kenna wha may joke yoursel'.

K

Kail hains bread.—Kame sindle came sair.—Kamesters are ay creeshy.

Keep woo and it will be dirt, keep lint and it will be silk.

Keep your ain fish guts to your ain sea-maws.

Keep your kill-dry'd taunts to your mouldy-hair'd maidens.

Keep your breath to cool your crowdie.

Keep your mouth close and your een open.

Kindness comes a-will, it canna be coft.

Kindness will creep whare it canna gang.

Kindle a candle at baith ends it will soon be done.

King's cauff's worth other fo'ks corn.—Kissing gans by favour.

King's cheese gaes hauf awa in pairings.

Kiss a carl and clap a carl, and that's the way to tine a carl.

Kythe in your ain colours that fo'k may ken you.

L

Ladies and turkies need delicate upbringing.
Laith to bed and laith to rise.—Lang straes are nae motes.
Lang fasting hains nae meat.—Learn young, learn fair.
Lang tongu'd wives gae lang wi' bairn.
Langest at fire soonest finds cauld.
Lang speaking part maun spill.—Love me love my dog.
Law's costly, tak a pint and gree.
Law-makers should na be law-breakers.
Laugh at leisure, ye may greet ere night.
Laugh and lay't down again.—Let alane maks mony loons.
Lay the head o' the sow to the tail o' the grice.
Learn the cat to the kirk and she'll ay be licking.
Letna the plough stand to kill a mouse.
Let a' treads live, quoth the wife, when she burnt her besom.
Let ay bell'd wathers break the snaw.
Let by-ganes be by-ganes.—Let horns gang wi' the hide.
Let him tak a spring on his ain fiddle.
Let him haud the bairn that aught the bairn.
Let him cool in the skin he het in.
Let ilka sheep hang by its ain shank.
Let the muckle horse get the muckle wonlyn.
Let the morn come and the meat wi't.
Let the kirk stand in the kirk-yard.—Live and let live.

Lie for him and he'll swear for you.—Little gear the less care.
Light supper mak lang life-days.—Like's an ill mark.
Little winning maks a heavy purse.—Love o'erlooks mony fauts.
Lightly come, lightly gane.—Little kend the less cared for.
Like draws to like, as a scabbed horse to a fail dyke.
Like Scotsmen, ay wise ahint the hand.
Likely lies aft i' the mire, when unlikely wins through.
Like the maidens o' Bayordine ye learn by the ear.
Like hens, ye rin ay to the tap o' the heap.
Like the bairns o' Falkirk, ye mind naething but mischief.
Like frien'less dogs mair sleep than meat.
Like the cat, fain fish wad ye eat, but ye are laith to weet your feet.
Like the wife wi' the mony daughters, the best comes hindmost.
Lippen to me but look to yoursel'.
Little Jock gets the little dish, and that hauds him lang little.
Little said is soon mended, little gear's soon spended.
Little wit i' the head maks muckle travel to the feet.
Little may an auld nag do that maunna nicher.
Live upon love as lavrocks do on leeks.
Loud on the loan was ne'er a gude milk cow.
Love and light winna hide.—Love me lightly love me lang.
Love's as warm among cotters as courtiers.
Love o'er het soonest cools.

M

Maidens shou'd be mim till they'r married, then they may burn kirks.
Maidens shou'd be mild and meek, quick to hear and slaw to speak.
Maidens tochers and ministers stipends are ay less than ca'd.
Mair hamely than welcome.—Mair haste the waur speed.
Mair by luck than gude guiding.—Malice is aye mindfu'.
Mak friends o' fremit fo'k.—Measure twice, cut but ance.
Mak the best o' an ill bargain you can.
Mak your hay when the sun shines.
May-bees flee not at this time o' the year.
Maybe your pot may need my clips.
Mealy-mou'd maids stand lang at the mill.
Muckle may fa' between the cup and the lip.
Mills and wives are ay wanting.—Mony hands mak light wark.
Mistress afore fo'k, gude wife behind backs, where lies the dish-clout?
Money is welcome in a dirten clout.
Mony a ane kisses the bairn for love o' the nurse.
Mony fair promises at marriage mak few at tocher-paying.
Mony say weel when it was ne'er waur.
Mony a ane serves a thankless master.
Mony ways to kill a dog tho' ye dinna hang him.
Mony cooks ne'er made gude kail.
Mony irons i' the fire part maun cool.
Mony a ane opens their pack and sells nae wares.

Mony a ane speers the gate they ken fu' weel.

My son's my son ay till he get a wife, my daughter's my daughter a'
the days o' her life.

N

Nae fool like an auld fool.—Nae friend like a friend in need.
Nae man can thrive unless his wife lets him.
Nae sooner up than her head's in the am'ry.
Nae safe wading in unco water.—Necessity hae nae law.
Nae wonder ye be auld like, ilka thing fashes ye.
Naething sae crouse as a new washen louse.
Naething's ill to be done when will's at hame.
Naething's to be done in haste but gripping of flaes.
Naething to do but draw in your stool and sit down.
Naething venture naething win.—New lords hae new laws.
Nane but fools and knaves lay wagers.
Nane can mak a bore but ye'll find a pin till't.
Nane can play the fool sae weel as a wise man.
Near's my sark but nearer's my skin.—Ne'er ower auld to learn.
Nearest the heart nearer the mou.—Ne'er rax aboon your reach.
Nearest the kirk the farthest frae gude.
Neck or naething the king loes nae cripples.
Need will gar an auld wife trot, and a naked man rin.
Ne'er draw your durk when a daunt will do.
Ne'er find faut wi' my shoon unless ye pay my cobbler.
Ne'er gae to the deil wi' a dish-clout about your head.
Ne'er gae me my death in a toom dish.—Ne'er quat certanty for hope.
Ne'er let on but laugh in your ain sleeve.

Ne'er marry a widow, unless her first man was hang'd.

Ne'er scad your lips in other fo'k's kail.

Ne'er seek a wife till ye ken what to do wi'.

Ne'er shaw your teeth unless ye can bite.

Ne'er strive against the stream.

Ne'er take a fore-hammer to break an egg, when ye can do it wi' a pen-
knife.—Nipping and scarting's Scotch fo'k's wooing.

Ne'er let the nose blush for the sins o' the mouth.

Nineteen naesays o' a maiden are ha'f a grant.

O

Ower haly was hang'd, and rough and sonsy wan awa'.

Ower muckle o' aething is gude for naething.

Ower mony grieves but hinders the wark.

O' twa ills choose the least.—Out o' debt out o' danger.

Out o' the peat-pot into the gutter.

P

Pay him hame in his ain coin.—Penny wise and pound foolish.

Pennyless sauls may pine in purgatory.

Pleying at law's like fighting through a whin buss, the harder the
blows the sairer the scar.

Poortith parts gude company.—Possession is eleven points o' the law.

Pride ne'er leaves its master till he get a fa'.

Poets and painters hae liberty to lie.

Put a coward to his metal and he'll fight the deil.

Put your hand nae farther than your sleeve will reach.

Put your hand i' the creel, and tak out an adder or an eel.

Q

Quey caufs are dear veal.—Quick returns mak rich.

R

Rackless youth maks ruefu' eild.—Raw leather raxes.

Raise nae mae deils than your able to lay.

Rather spoil your joke than tine your friend.

Raw dawds mak fat lads.—Rich fou'k hae routh o' friends.

Rich fo'k's wit rives puir fo'k's jaws.—Rob Peter to pay Paul.

Ride fair and jaup nane.—Right wrangs nae man.

Rob Gib's contract, stark love and kindness.

Rome was nae bigget in ae day.—Royet lads may mak sober men.

Rooks and writers are ay to be found about ruined houses.

Roose the ford as ye find it.—Rue and time grow baith in ae garden.

S

Sair cravers are ay ill payers.—Satan reproving sin.
Saut, quoth the sutor, when he had eaten a cow a' but the tail.
Seethe stanes in butter the broo will be gude.
Second thoughts are best.—Ser' yoursel till your bairns come in age.
Set a beggar on horseback he'll ride to the deil.
Set a stout heart to a stay brae.—Shame's past the shade o' your hair.
Sharp stomachs mak short graces.—Stown dints are sweetest.
Shallow waters mak maist din.—Sinle seen soon forgotten.
She's as leal a maiden as her man left her.
She hauds up her head like a hen drinking water.
She brack her elbow at the kirk door.—Standing dubs gather dirt.
She'll wear like a horse shoe, ay the langer the clearer.
Short fo'k are soon angry, their heart's soon at their mou.
Slaw at meat slaw at wark.—Sorrow and ill weather come unsent for.
Some hae a hantle o' fauts ye'er only a neer-do-weel.
Souters and tailors count hours.—Speak o' the deil and he'll appear.
Speak gude o' pipers, your father was a fiddler.
Speak when your spoken till, and drink when you're drucken till.
Strike the iron as lang as it's het.

T

Tak your will o't as the cat did o' the haggis.
Tak the bit and the buffet wi't.—Tak me not up before I fa'.
Tak your ain will and then ye'll no die o' the pet.
Tak a hair o' the dog that bit you.—That's Halkerton's cow.
Tak nae mair on your back than you're able to carry.
Tak a man by his word and a cow by her horn.
Tarry breeks pay nae fraught.—Tapped hens like cock crawling.
Tell nae your fae when your foot's slipping.—That's a tee'd ba'.
That bout cam ne'er out o' your bag.—The best is ay cheapest.
That's carrying saut to Dysart and puddings to Tranent.
That's the piece a step-bairn ne'er gat.—Time tries a'.
That winna be a mot i' your marriage.—The deil's ay gude to his ain.
The back and the belly hauds every ane busy.
The bairn speaks i'the field what he hears at the fireside.
The bird maun flighter that flees wi' ae wing.
The better day the better deed.—The warld is bound to nae man.
The blind man's peck should be weel measur'd.
The cure may be waur than the disease.
The death o' ae bairn winna skail a house.
The dorty dame may fa' i' the dirt.—The deil's bairns hae deil's luck.
The deil ay drives his hogs to an ill market.
The deil's gaen o'er John Wabster.—The e'ening brings a hame.
The farthest way about is aft the nearest gate hame.

The richer the souter, the blacker his thumbs.

The first fuf o' a fat haggis is ay the bauldest.

The gravest fish is an oyster,

The gravest bird's an owl;

The gravest beast's an ass,

And the gravest man's a fool.

The kings errand may come in a cadger's gate.

The langer we live we see the mair fairlies.

The mae the merrier, the fewer the better cheer.

The masters e'e maks the horse fat.—The still sow eats up the draff.

The simple man's the beggar's brither.

The subject's love is the kings life guard.

The smith's mare and the souter's wife are ay warst shod.

The thiefer like the better sodger.—The tod's whelps are ill to tame.

The thing that lie nae in your gate breaks na your shins.

The thing that's in your wame's not in your testament.

The thrift o' you was the death o' your gude-dame.

The tod keeps his ain hole clean.

The worth o' a thing is best kend by the want o't.

The wife's ay welcome that comes wi' a crooked oxter.

There's mony a true tale tauld in jest.

There's mukle to do when burghers ride.

There's nane sae blind as them that winna see.

There's naething ill said that's nae ill tane.

There's nae place like hame, as the deil said when he fan' himsel in the
Court o' Session.

There was ne'er a silly Jocky but there was as silly a Jenny.

There's beild aneath an auld man's baird.
There is a teugh sinew in an auld wife's heel.
There is a differ betwixt the piper and his bitch.
There is a wawp i' the raip.—Thole weel is gude for burning.
There is a sliddery stane before the ha' door.
There is as gude fish i' the sea as e'er cam out o't.
There grows nae grass at the cross.—Thoughts beguil maidens.
There is life in a mussel as lang as she cheeps.—Time tries a'.
There is little for the rake after the shool.—Tine heart and a's gane.
They are ay gude that are far awa.—True blue will ne'er stain.
They are like the grices, if you kittle their wame they fa' on their
backs.
They hae need o' a canny cook that hae but ae egg to their dinner.
They ne'er saw great dainties that think a haggis a feast.
They shou'd kiss the gude-wife that wad win the gude-man.
They that see you a' day winna break the house for you at night.
They that get a word o' soon rising may lie a' day.
They that laugh in the morning may greet ere night.
They that drink langest live langest.
They that hae routh o' butter may lay it thick on their scone.
They that lie down for love shou'd rise for hunger.
They were scant o' bairns that brought you up.
They were never fain that fidg'd, nor fa' that licked dishes.
They ne'er ga'e wi' the speet but they get wi' the ladle.
Three can keep a secret if twa be awa.
Time and tide will tarry for nae man.

Touch a gawd horse on the back and he'll fling.

Tramp on a snail and she'll shoot out her horns.

Twa blacks will ne'er mak a white.

Twine two, your minny was a gude spinner.

U

Up hill spare me, down hill tak tent to thee.

Use makes perfectness.

W

Wanton kittens mak douce cats.—When drink's in wit's out.
Wae's the wife that want's the tongue, but weel's the man that gets her.
Weans maun creep ere they gang.—Women's wark's ne'er done.
Wedding and ill wintering tame baith man and beast.
Weel kens the mouse when the cat's out o' the house.
Welcom's the best dish in the kitchen.
We'll ne'er ken the worth o' the water till the well gae dry.
We're ay to learn as lang's we live.—We canna baith sup and blaw.
We'll bark oursels ere we buy dogs sae dear.
We may ken your eild by the runkles o' your horn.
We may ken your meaning by your mumping.
What's gotten owre the deil's back will gang awa under his belly.
When ae door stecks anither opens.—Wilfu' waste maks waefu' want.
When friends meet hearts warm.—Woo sellers ken ay woo buyers.
When the tod preaches tak tent o' the lambs.
When the wame's fou, the banes wad be at rest.
When petticoats woo, brecks come speed.
When you're serv'd a' the geese are water'd.
While the pow's shaving the lice maun flit.
When ye're gaun and coming the gate's no toom.
Where the dyke's laighest it is eithiest to loup.
Where there's owre muckle courtesy, there's little kindness.
Winter thunder bodes simmer hunger.

Work for nought maks fo'k dead sweer.

Y

Ye're as lang o' tuning your pipes as ane wad play a spring.
Ye cam a day after the fair.—Ye hae gotten a ravel'd hesp o't.
Ye cut lang whangs out o' ither fo'k's leather.
Ye canna preach out o' your ain pupit.—Ye hae a crap for a' corn.
Ye canna get leave to thrive for thrang.
Ye drive the plough before the owsen.
Ye hae gien the wolfe the wedder to keep.
Ye hae sitten your time, as mony a gude hen has done.
Ye hae o'er foul feet to come sae far ben.
Ye hae tint your ain stomach and fund a tike's.
Ye hae the wrang sow by the lug.—Ye ken wha drinkers dree.
Ye kenna wha may cool your ain kail yet.
Yelping curs may rise mastiffs.—Ye're mair fley'd than hurt.
Ye may get waur bodes or Beltane.
Ye may dight your neb and flee up.
Ye mete my pease by your ain peck.
Ye ne'er saw green cheese but your een reel'd.
Ye ride sae near the rumple ye'll let nane loup on behind you.
Ye're like a miller's dog, you lick your lips ere the pock be opened.
Ye're sae keen o' the clocking you'll die in the nest.
Ye're nae chicken for a' your cheeping.
Ye're come o' blude, and sae's a pudding.
Ye're like hens, ye rin ay to the heap.

Ye shape shoon by your ain shachel'd feet.
Ye watna what wife's ladle may cogue your kail.
Your bread's baken, you may hing by your girdle.

Transcriber's Note

List of minor amendments made to the text:

[Page 12](#), “mauu” changed to “maun” (He that wad eat the kirkel maun crack the nut.)

[Page 13](#), “diel” changed to “deil” (If the deil find you idle he’ll set you to wark.)

[Page 16](#), “Kindess” changed to “Kindness” (Kindness will creep whare it canna gang.)

[Page 22](#), “bleu” changed to “blue” (True blue will ne’er stain.)

Defective punctuation was amended as necessary without further note.

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